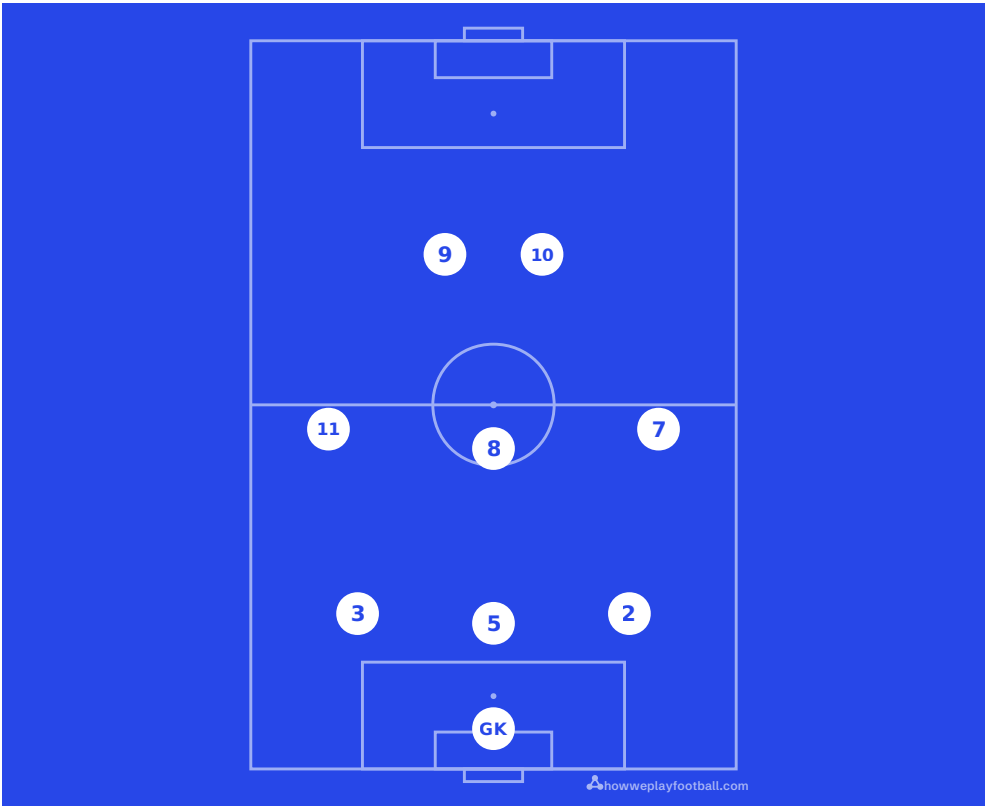
9V9 FORMATION GUIDE

3-3-2

A starting shape, four playing principles and a job for every position.



INTRODUCTION

WELCOME

Three protect. Three connect. Two work together. A 9v9 starting picture with three defenders, three midfielders and two forwards who must offer different options.

WHO IT'S FOR

Volunteer grassroots football coaches and parents looking for a shared starting picture for 9v9.

The shape helps us explain jobs. Players should still have opportunities to try different roles.

HOW TO USE IT

- Learn the starting shape.
- Pick one of the four principles to talk about.
- Give each player a short, useful question.
- Use the online diagrams when you want to see movement.

IN THIS GUIDE

01 Starting shape

02 Four playing principles

03 A job for every player

04 Coaching reminders and notes

HOW TO READ THIS GUIDE

READING THE DIAGRAMS

We always attack up the page. These pictures capture a moment, not a fixed running lane.

OUR PLAYER

A blue player with a number.

THEM

A player from the opposition.

BALL

Where the ball is in this moment.

MOVEMENT

A solid arrow shows a possible run.

PASS

A broken arrow can show a pass.

SPACE

A highlighted area draws your eye to a decision.



9V9 · 3-3-2

A STARTING SHAPE, NOT A FIXED PLAN FOR EVERY SECOND.

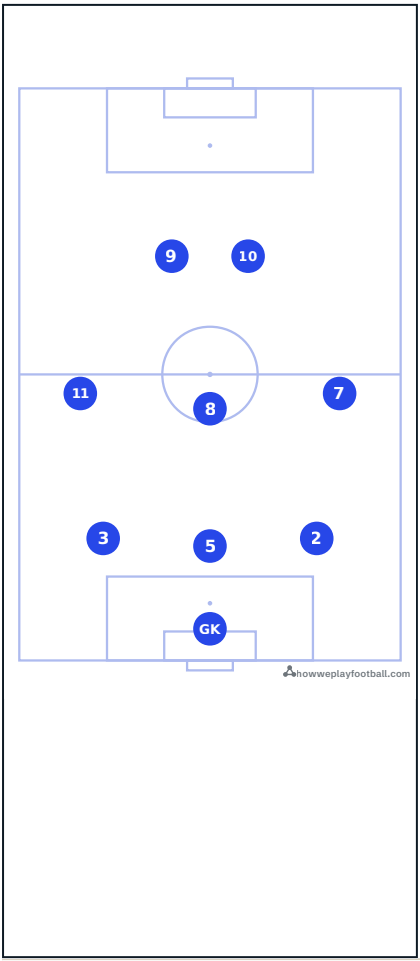
9v9 · The 3-3-2 · howweplayfootball.com

The numbers identify jobs in the drawings. They do not lock children into one position.

CHAPTER 01 · THE STARTING PICTURE

STARTING SHAPE

Three protect. Three connect. Two work together. A 9v9 starting picture with three defenders, three midfielders and two forwards who must offer different options.



THIS SHAPE GIVES US

- a recognisable three-player defence
- a three-player midfield linking both ends
- a partner for each of our two forwards
- opportunities to use width and combinations

REMEMBER

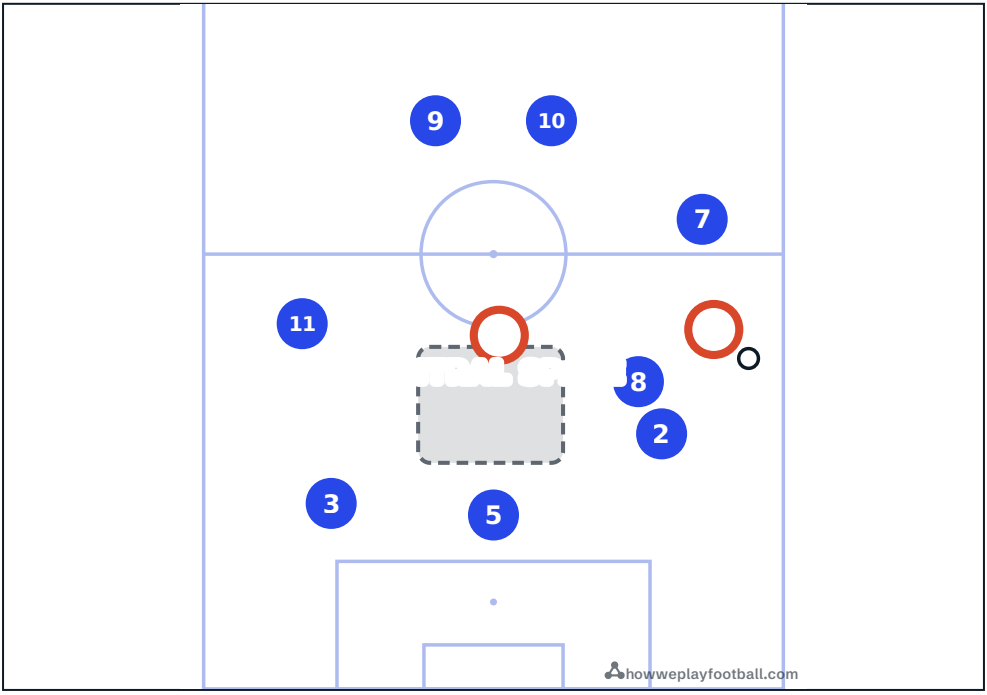
SAME STARTING SHAPE. DIFFERENT DECISIONS AS THE BALL MOVES.

9v9 · The 3-3-2 · Indicative player starting positions

PRINCIPLE 01 OF 04 · PICTURE ONE

MIDDLE FIRST

Protect the route to our goal before chasing wide. Protect the middle before committing more than one player to the ball.



ALL CHASE

Example: more than one player follows the ball wide, leaving a possible route through the middle.

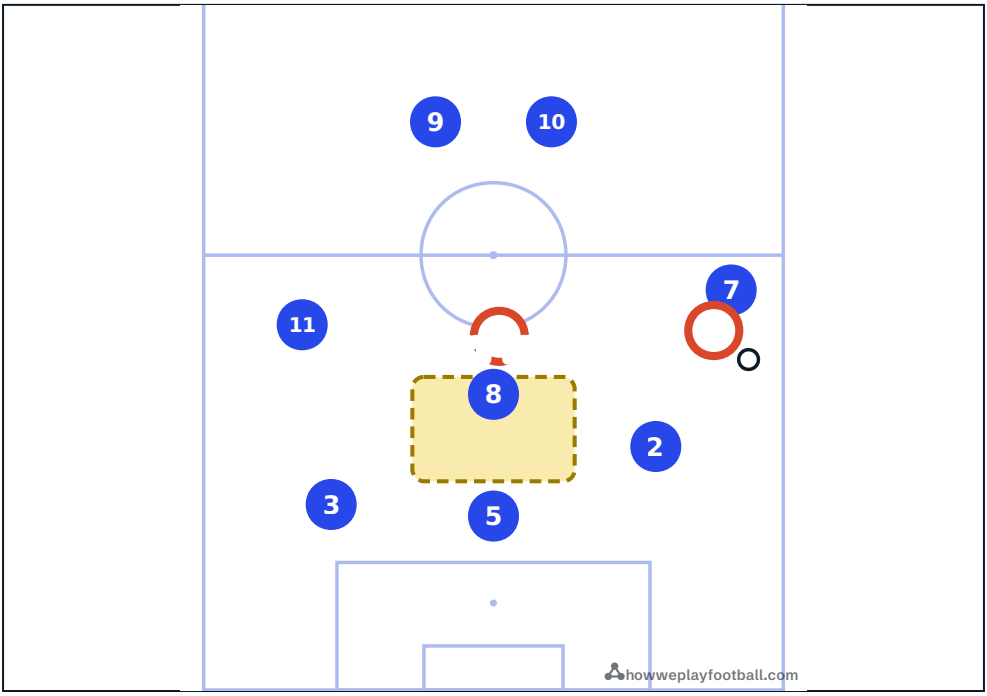
SAY IT

“PRESS OR COVER?”

If somebody steps towards the ball, somebody else needs to protect the central route.

PRINCIPLE 01 OF 04 · PICTURE TWO

MIDDLE FIRST



PRESS AND COVER

Example: the ball-side player applies pressure while 8 stays connected to the centre.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- Watch whether pressure on the ball has cover behind it.
- Check whether 8 remains connected to the back three.
- Decide who can press rather than sending everybody towards the same player.

PRINCIPLE 02 OF 04 · PICTURE ONE

BALL SIDE WIDE, FAR SIDE IN

Give width near the ball; the far midfielder comes inside to help. Support the player in possession without crowding their space.



NEAR SIDE WIDE

Example: 7 offers width while the far midfielder 11 starts wider.

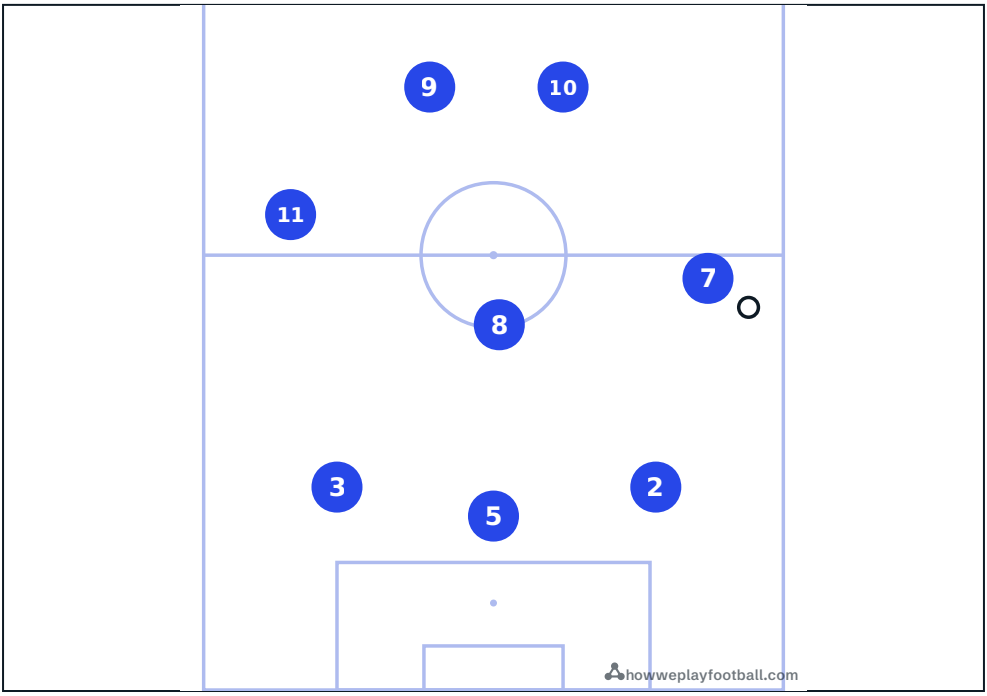
SAY IT

“STAY WIDE OR TUCK IN?”

If a switch of play is on, the far player may need to remain wider.

PRINCIPLE 02 OF 04 · PICTURE TWO

BALL SIDE WIDE, FAR SIDE IN



READ THE SWITCH

Consider: 11 may remain wider if a switch of play is useful. The correct decision depends on pressure and space.

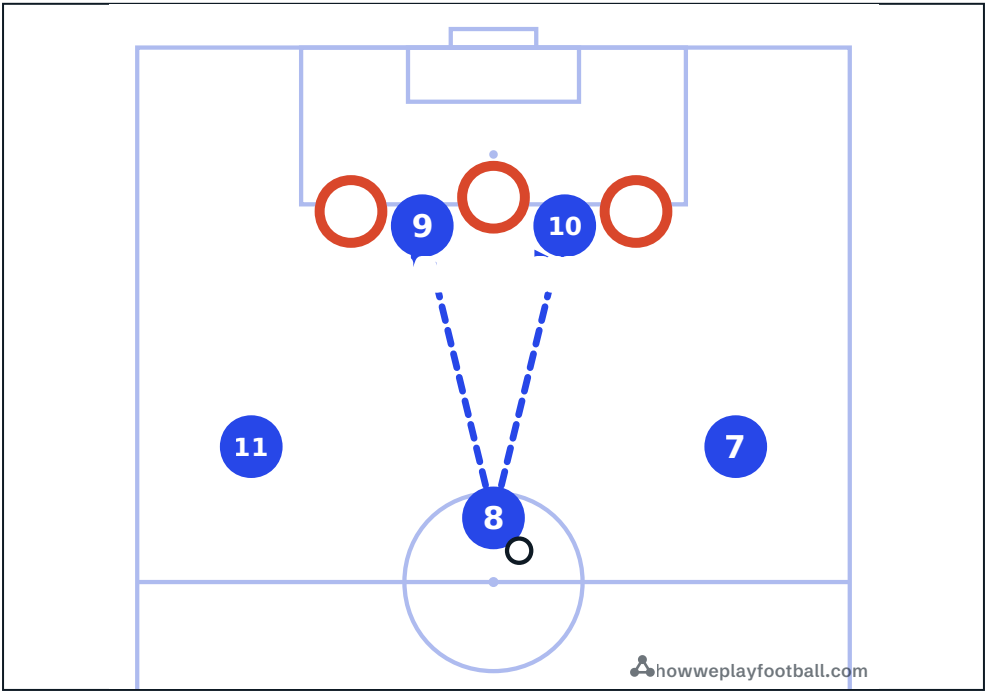
WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- Is 7 or 11 offering a useful wide pass?
- Can 8 connect play without becoming isolated?
- Does the far midfielder need to come inside, or stay available for a switch?

PRINCIPLE 03 OF 04 · PICTURE ONE

ONE COMES, ONE GOES

Our two forwards shouldn't make the same run. One forward can offer a pass to feet while the other threatens space.



SAME LINE

9 and 10 both stand on the last defensive line. One defender can mark both passing lanes.

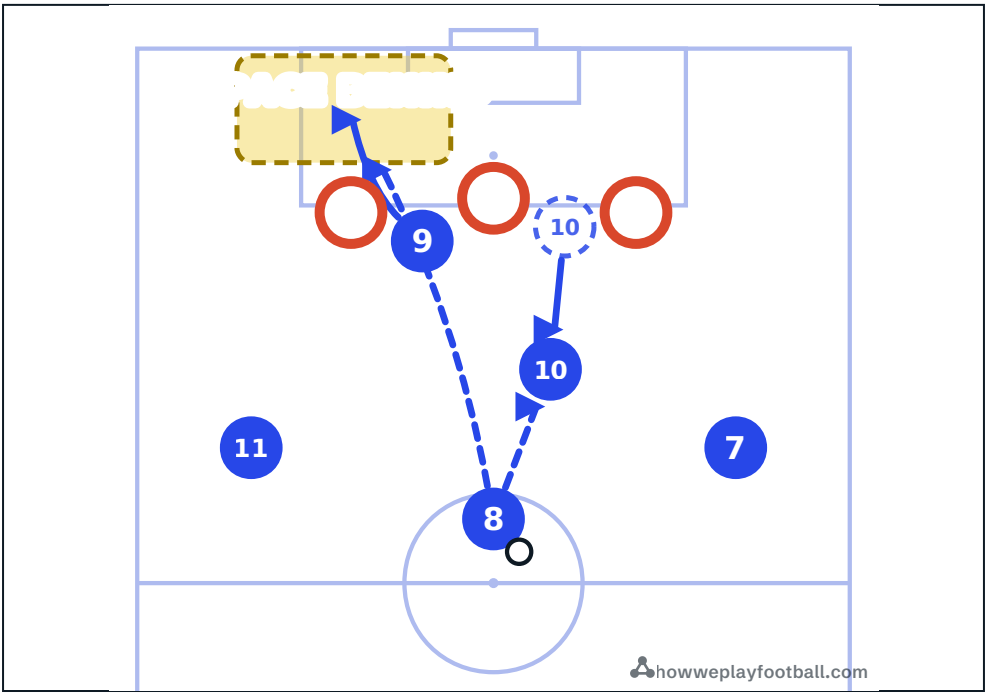
SAY IT

“OFFER FEET OR THREATEN BEHIND?”

These roles can reverse. Any run beyond opponents must be timed to stay onside.

PRINCIPLE 03 OF 04 · PICTURE TWO

ONE COMES, ONE GOES



10 COMES, 9 GOES

10 comes short. 9 stays high or moves into a channel.

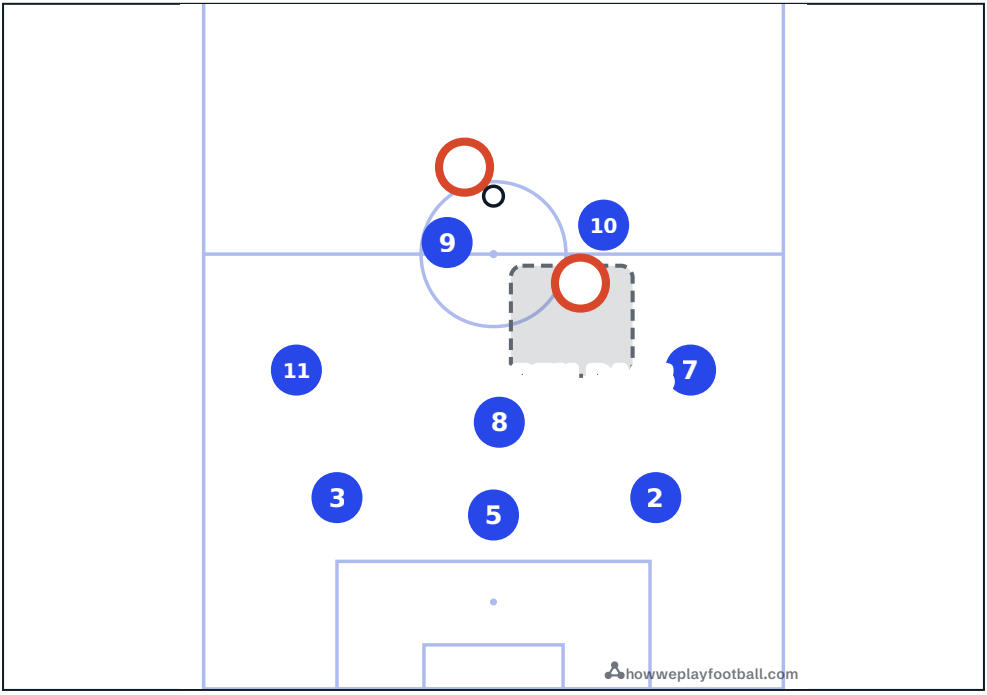
WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- Are 9 and 10 offering different passing options?
- Is 8 close enough to combine with the forwards?
- Can a forward recognise when there is no useful space to run into?

PRINCIPLE 04 OF 04 · PICTURE ONE

GO TOGETHER, RECOVER TOGETHER

If one presses, others close the next pass; if beaten, recover as a unit. Pressing depends on help from nearby teammates, not one player chasing alone.



PRESS ALONE

Example: one forward presses but the next passing route remains open.

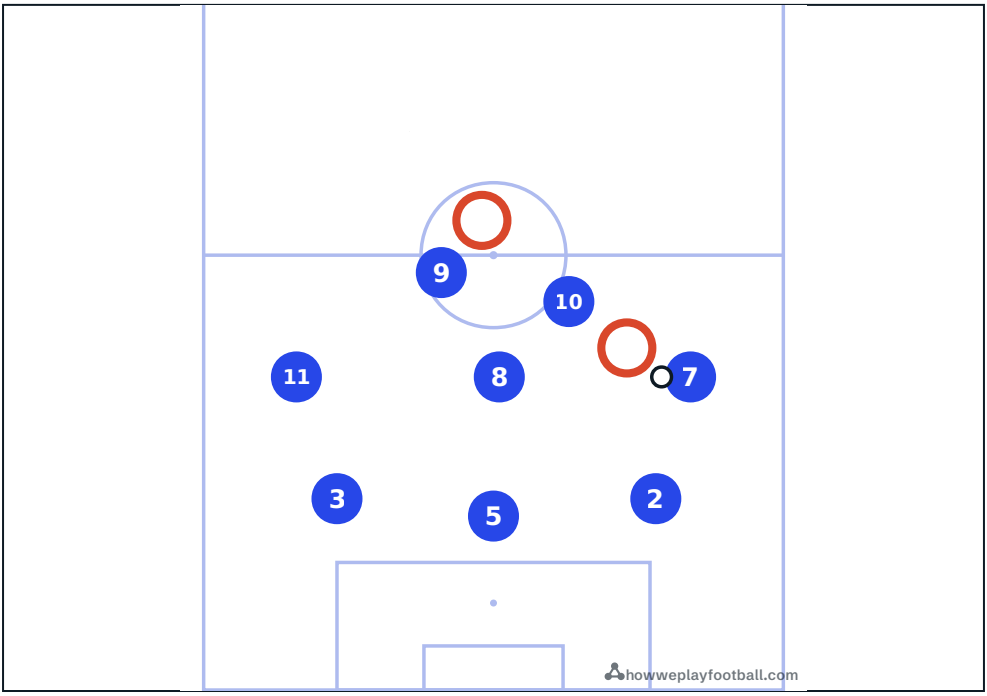
SAY IT

“ARE TEAMMATES CLOSE ENOUGH TO HELP?”

The first defender delays; others must decide which spaces and passing options to protect.

PRINCIPLE 04 OF 04 · PICTURE TWO

GO TOGETHER, RECOVER TOGETHER



RECOVER AS A UNIT

Example: if the first press is beaten, nearby teammates recover together instead of chasing the same opponent.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- Does the first presser have help behind and alongside?
- Can the other forward restrict the easy central pass?
- After pressure is beaten, does the team recover into useful positions?

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

GK GOALKEEPER

Start, see, speak



YOUR JOBS

- Start by looking for a simple pass to a teammate who can receive.
- Keep talking to the back three about opponents and space.
- Before choosing a pass, think about what happens if we lose it.

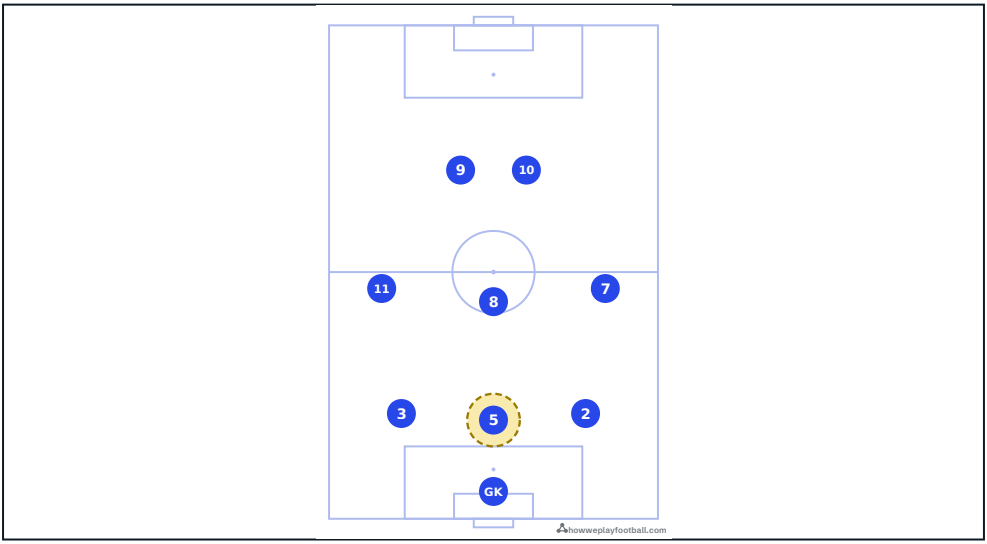
ASK YOURSELF

“WHO IS FREE, AND WHAT HAPPENS IF I PASS THERE?”

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

5 CENTRE-BACK

See the whole picture



YOUR JOBS

- Help organise the three defenders and recognise danger through the centre.
- When stepping towards an opponent, know which teammate can provide cover.
- Connect with 8 when there is a sensible passing option.

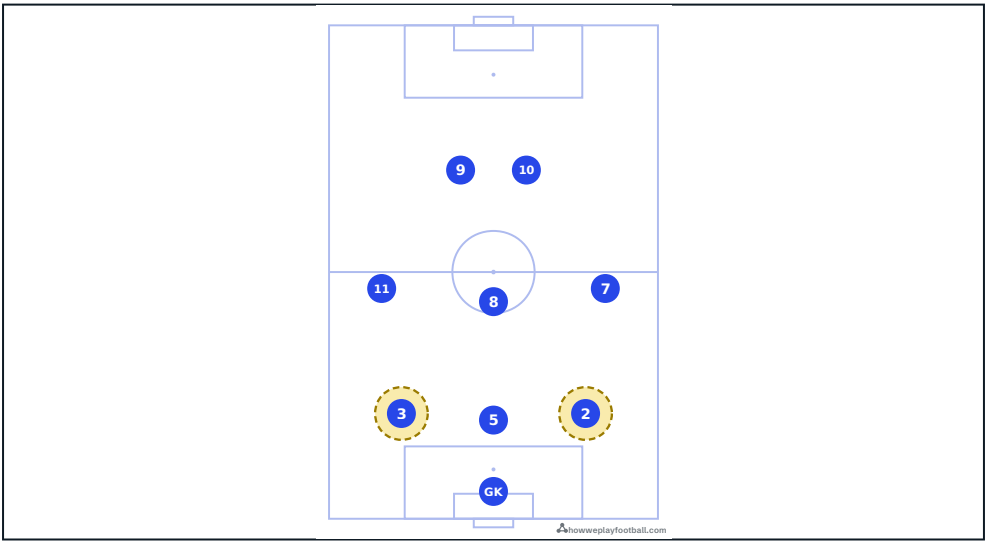
ASK YOURSELF

“IF I STEP IN, WHO'S BEHIND ME?”

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

3 · 2 OUTSIDE DEFENDERS

Defend, support, cover



YOUR JOBS

- Recognise when to challenge a wide opponent and when to protect the centre.
- Support teammates in possession without both leaving the defence exposed.
- Work with 5 and the nearby midfielder to share pressure and cover.

ASK YOURSELF

“AM I PRESSING OR COVERING?”

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

8 CENTRAL MIDFIELDER

Connect both ends



YOUR JOBS

- Give teammates a useful central passing option when we have the ball.
- Notice when moving towards the ball would leave an open route through midfield.
- Keep connected to both the back three and two forwards.

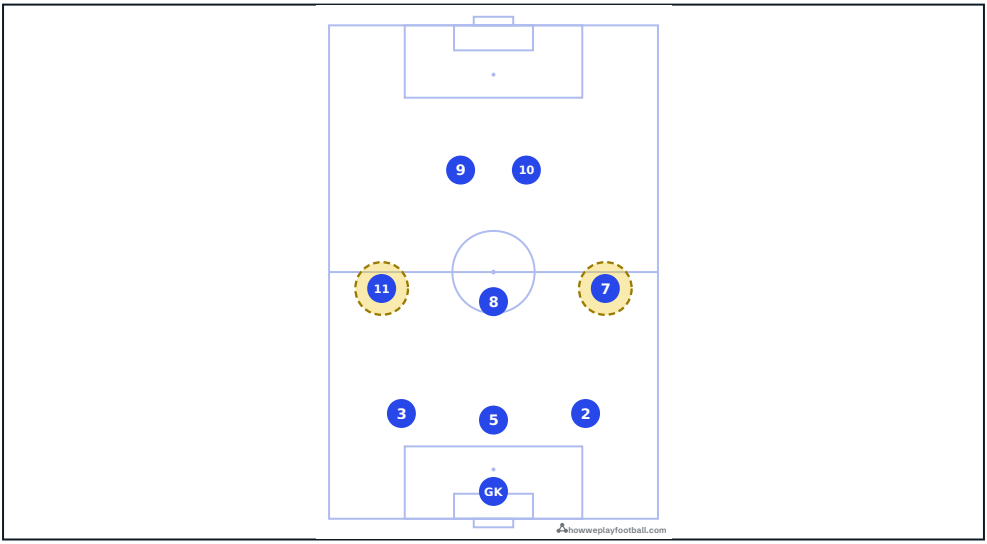
ASK YOURSELF

“CAN THEY PLAY THROUGH US IF I MOVE?”

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

11 · 7 WIDE MIDFIELDERS

Width and hard work



YOUR JOBS

- Offer width when your team needs an outside passing option.
- When the ball is on the far side, consider whether coming inside would help your team.
- Recover to support the defence when possession changes.

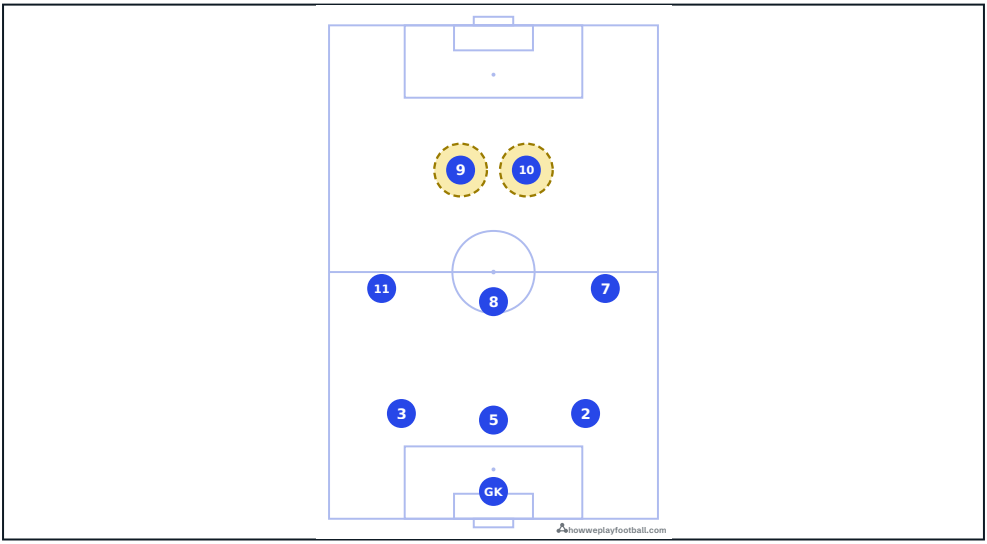
ASK YOURSELF

“SHOULD I BE WIDE OR INSIDE RIGHT NOW?”

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

9 · 10 TWO FORWARDS

Partners, not passengers



YOUR JOBS

- Offer different options: one may come short while the other stays higher.
- Recognise when you can pressure the ball and when your partner needs help.
- Stay connected to the midfield instead of waiting together for a long pass.

ASK YOURSELF

“WHERE IS MY PARTNER GOING?”

YOUR NOTES

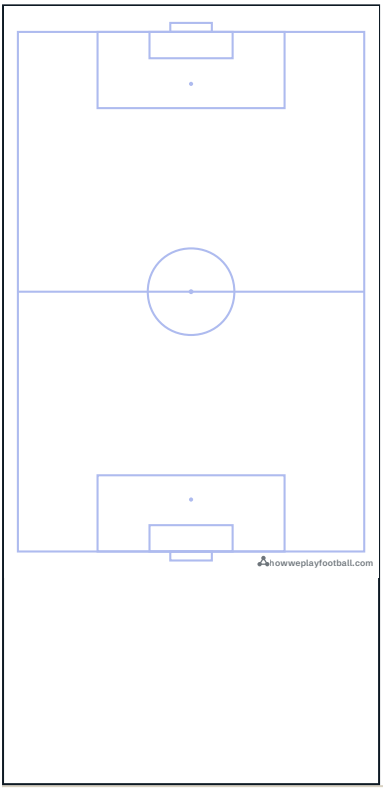
ON THE TOUCHLINE

01 Press or cover?

02 Stay wide or tuck in?

03 Offer feet or threaten behind?

04 Are teammates close enough to help?



KEEP GOING ONLINE

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SCAN FOR THE ONLINE GUIDE

THE 3-3-2 ONLINE

Explore the full guide with animated tactical diagrams.

howweplayfootball.com/formations/9v9/3-3-2/

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HOW WE PLAY FOOTBALL

Helping your team take the next step.

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